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RARE CRAKE SHOWS UP AT ADYAR POONGA

Sagarika Gupta takes a video of a Slaty-legged crane with her mobile phone; one of the restrictions that go with the walker's pass is that the user should not carry a camera with them **P3**



BIG QUESTIONS FOR YOUNG MINDS

Philosophising is usually, and often erroneously, associated with hoary hair. Rhea Kuthoor seeks to break that stereotype by introducing children to philosophical inquiry **P6**

OMR gated communities *glaringly absent*

While a few gated communities elsewhere in Chennai served as voting centres, the IT corridor did not open its account



A policeman helps voters at Semmancheri housing board tenements off OMR. PHOTO RAVINDRAN R

PRINCE FREDERICK

The election coverage across media had a sprinkle of reports from Chennai about gated communities serving as voting centres, and surprisingly, none of these communities had an OMR address. That is odd, as odd as having Abhishek Sharma batting through the entire length of the power play, facing a healthy number of balls, but not having one sixer to his name. If gated communities ever felt at home anywhere it would be OMR. They would find themselves among kith and kin, given the number of communities nestling on the arterial road. OMR is a natural when it comes to "scoring" gated communities, it keeps adding them to its score at a clip and effortlessly too.

Harsha Koda, co-founder of Federation of OMR Residents Association, notes that efforts were on to have poll-

ing booths at a decent number of gated communities on OMR, but the efforts, though made in earnest, did not fructify.

He elaborates that the Election Commission did reach out to around 15-20 communities along OMR.

Harsha points out that even before FOMRRA started the ACTIVOTE campaign to assist voters with their VoterID corrections last year, he had spoken to N. Gopalswami, the former Chief Election Commissioner of India, who is based in Chennai.

"During that conversation, I asked about the feasibility of setting up polling booths within gated communities. He responded positively, saying there was a strong possibility. He also offered to speak with the current Election Commissioner of Tamil Nadu and facilitate a connection. Following that, officials did reach out to us. The idea was to establish dedicated polling booths within communities so that residents would not

have to step out, thereby potentially increasing voter turnout. We believed this could significantly improve participation," Harsha explains.

Subsequently, in October-November last year, the Election Commission sent a formal communication towards this end, officials inspecting several communities with the objecting of selecting them for establishment of voting centres for the 2026 TN Assembly elections.

The exercise did not produce what was desired. One after another, the communities that were considered for establishing voting centres were rejected. There was a pattern to what went against the communities that had made it to the shortlist.

Harsha says the primary concern cited was the inability to adequately secure these locations. Logistical issues also threw a spanner in the works: clubhouses were located on the first or second floor, which was deemed unsuitable.

Among the major constraints was the requirement to secure the premises for an extended duration; two days prior to polling, the polling day itself, and at least a day after. This meant clubhouses would be unavailable for regular use for nearly five to six days, which created resistance within the communities, adds Harsha. FOMRRA decided not to pursue the idea further for the current

election cycle; but is determined to make this work for the next election, which could the local bodies elections.

The FOMRRA co-founder observes that rather than engaging in the futile business of crying bitterly over spilt milk, the team chose to channel its energy into helping voters in other ways. He cites the intensified efforts around SIR, setting up "a

helpline that operated daily for about 15 days, from 8 p.m. to 9 p.m., using a Google Meet link" to ensure residents completed their SIR forms.

Harsha believes that these efforts have contributed handsomely to the stats that came out on election day; voter turnout registering 80.4% in Sholinganallur constituency and 88% in Tirupur constituency.

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NOW IN THORAIPAKKAM, OMR



Marie Claire Paris, the French brand of Salon and Nails chain, recently inaugurated their second Salon & Nails store in Chennai at Thoraipakkam, OMR (Grace Towers, above Challani Jewellery, next to KFC/Pizza Hut)



★ **Shri Jayathilal Challani,**
Chairman, Challani Group of Companies, graced the occasion as Chief guest.

Marie Claire Paris was started in 1937 in Paris as a fashion magazine and later diversified into many business verticals such as garments, leatherware, shoes, perfumes, salon, etc. In India, Marie Claire Paris has many premium and luxury Salons across multiple cities such as Bangalore, Hyderabad, Lucknow, Chennai, Warangal, etc.

★ The Inauguration was attended by many customers, brand partners, business partners and patrons.



“ Speaking at the event, **Shri Jayanthilal Challani,** mentioned that he was extremely impressed by the spacious and luxurious ambience, services offered, facilities available and the quality of stylists and beauticians, at the Marie Claire Paris Salon. Also, there is considerable privacy available to the clients. ”

Ms Sharmila Manohar, Franchisee of Marie Claire Paris, Thoraipakkam, explained that Marie Claire Paris is a unisex premium Salon which offers a wide range of hair, skin, beauty and nails services viz hair styling, colour, hair spa, botox, nanoplastia, premium facials including hydrafacial, pedi/mani cure, waxing, nail services, etc. She also highlighted that the Marie Claire Salon is located on the service road right on OMR main road and has ample parking.



★ **Mr P.S.Sriram, Master Franchisee,** mentioned that Marie Claire Paris is proud to open their Salon in a premium and buzzing location like Thoraipakkam and OMR region, and Marie Claire Paris is looking forward to pampering the residents of Thoraipakkam.



★ **Mr. Vittal Shetty,** Marie Claire Paris, India, mentioned that Marie Claire is fast expanding its franchise network across pan India and Chennai is one of the high potential markets with considerable new Franchise enquiries coming in.

For service appointments at Marie Claire Paris, Thoraipakkam, Contact : 9840029856.

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Rare crane shows up at Adyar Poonga; camera not in sight

During her morning walk at the green facility on April 21, Sagarika Gupta takes a video of a Slaty-legged crane with her mobile phone; one of the restrictions that go with the walker's pass is that the user should not carry a camera with them

PRINCE FREDERICK

The high-resolution image of a lifer is to a birder what a new degree certificate is to an over-qualified but still compulsive degree hoarder. For the elucidation of the chirp-challenged constituency, a lifer is a bird species a birder has clapped eyes on for the first time; and the rarer the feathers, the more treasured the photo of the bird that has been clicked. Birder Sagarika Gupta is disconsolate with the disappointment of a studious person who has completed a rare and brow-bending degree successfully, but is denied a certificate for some strange reason.

On April 21, during a morning walk at the Adyar Poonga, a Slaty-legged crane had crossed Sagarika's path, and if ever she bitterly regretted not having a camera with a telephoto lens at hand, this was the time.

Only the previous week, after multiple applications, Sagarika had secured a walker's pass, one that provided her access to the green facility for walking, and not photographing avian life or anything else. As she puts it, the walker's access comes with well-etched restrictions, and a camera is on the restricted list. She therefore had to make do with the marble phone, and with it, she clicked a video of the bird that was strutting around in a heavily shaded undergrowth.

It was around 6.50 a.m., and because of where the bird was found, in a thick, shaded undergrowth, on the side of the walkway closer to the waterway, lighting was not in her favour. As those known to her who have visited the Poonga had informed her that Orange-headed thrush sighting was possible out there,

A Slaty-legged crane photographed by Sathya Narayanan Sridhar at Sithalapakkam on December 23, 2023 and posted on iNaturalist.

she was half expecting see one. Given its rarity in these parts, a Slaty-legged crane was the last feather she had expected to see on the walk. As this crane has a touch of orange to it, at the first, cursory look, she imagined that an Orange-headed thrust was moving about in the undergrowth.

Fortunately, binoculars are allowed along with the mobile phone, and upon peering through that instrument of magnification, she saw the bird for what it was. Though this was the first time she was seeing a Slaty-legged crane in the field, she had seen it in pixels before. Sagarika

notes she delayed taking a video of the bird as she did not want to startle it with her sudden movements.

The Slaty-legged crane "treads softly" in and around Chennai, and reportedly, only two records of the species exist, and both on iNaturalist. Sagarika has entered her sighting on eBird with the video of the bird. This writer got in

touch with Sathya Narayanan Sridhar, one of the two birders who have documented a Slaty-legged crane sighting with photograph on iNaturalist. Sathya Narayanan Sridhar had sighted the species at Sithalapakkam on December 23, 2023; and he has shared with *The Hindu Downtown* an image of the Slaty-legged crane he spotted that memorable day.





▼ Bhuvaneswari Suresh and daughter Atchaya Shri.

In Class X with the daughter

Family circumstances had forced her to discontinue schooling. Now, after two decades, Bhuvaneswari Suresh is appearing for Class X exams along with her daughter who has multiple disabilities

LIFFY THOMAS

Twenty-three years after she left formal schooling, Bhuvaneswari Suresh is thumbing through her textbooks again to study and complete what she left unfinished. On April 22, the mother of two with disabilities, took up the English exam through National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS).

As she goes through these exams, she has a rare company: her 15-year-old daughter with multiple disabilities, S.B. Atchaya Shri, is also appearing for the Class X exam through NIOS.

Hailing from Tiruchirappalli, Bhuvaneswari had to drop out of school after Class IX due to the financial situation at home.

"I wanted to study, but by 18 I was married off and the thought of completing my schooling only got

postponed with responsibility at home," says the 35-year-old mother.

Two years after she was born, Atchaya Shri suffered brain fever that resulted in complete loss of hearing in her left ear and partial loss in the right. She was also diagnosed with cerebral palsy.

The family moved to Chennai for treatment and schooling for Atchaya and Bhuvaneswari's dream of studying had to take a backseat. In 2016, her second daughter was born and she was later diagnosed with cerebral palsy.

Bhuvaneswari's life revolved around taking care of her two daughters and ensuring they got the best therapy and schooling.

After a stint at a school in Taramani, Atchaya moved to Clarke School for Children with Special Needs in her Class VI.

This was no easy journey. The mother and daughter travel on a two-wheeler from their home in Pallavaram to the school in R.K. Salai.

"My younger one goes to a special school in Madipakkam, so my husband drops her in the morning. In the evening, I pick both of them," she says.

Bhuvaneswari never expected the teachers at Clarke's School were igniting a spark in her. "They started nudging me to clear my Class X along with my daughter as I was anyway helping her at home," says the mother grateful for the support she received from

I studied in Tamil medium and am now appearing in English medium; and that is part of the challenge

Empowering special children



Founded in 1970 by Founder Director P. Leelavathy (Late) and Founder Secretary S.K. Nagarajan (Late), Clarke School for Children with Special Needs caters to those with hearing impairment, intellectual disabilities, autism and

deafblindness. Besides government certified vocational courses, the school offers training in table tennis, art, crafts and drawing. It is currently open for admissions to the new academic year.

For details, call 9150334888. Visit www.theclarkeschool.com

all teachers.

In July 2025, the school got her name registered for the NIOS examination and also started helping her with necessary materials.

Bhuvaneswari's big apprehension was about whether she can study after a gap of two decades and with her daughters requiring continuous care and attention.

"I studied in Tamil medium and am now appearing in English medium; that is part of the challenge," says Bhuvaneswari. She studies at night for an hour and early in the morning before her household chores begin.

She has also sat in her daughter's class to understand new topics. "During the break, teachers helps me clarify my doubts," she says.

Of the five papers, Bhuvaneswari has decided to take Tamil and Data Entry exams in October.

Bhuvaneswari is grateful to her husband, K. Suresh, and extended family members for the support extended to her. Atchaya, she says, has shown remarkable improvement with the attention given at the school.

Jayanthi Narayanan, principal, Clarke School, says this year they have five children with multiple disabilities and five with intellectual disabilities appearing for Class X through NIOS; and three students in Class XII.

"When parents are educated they can guide their children better. We encourage many of them to become special educators for which they must have completed schooling," says Jayanthi, who has been with the school for the last four decades. She is grateful for the support by honorary secretary S.N. Srikanth.

Polling day pulse

Here are visuals from across polling booths in Chennai Metropolitan Area, even those in far-flung Tiruvallur, that display the exercise of people's power with punctuations of human moments. In a relief from the standard image of a polling booth plonked inside the premises of an educational institution, here and there, residents queued inside gated communities to get their finger inked. These living spaces had been turned into voting centres. There was the heart-tugging image of a disabled woman seated in a modified tricycle, one crowned with a roof to keep the nosey sun out. Volunteers were stepping in to assist seniors. Green booths spared a thought for the planet. The message was loud and clear: impressive voter participation and an equally commendable effort to break down barriers



Residents queue up to cast their vote at Prince apartment on Ilaya Street in Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar constituency. This was among the gated communities the Election Commission of India had turned into voting centres.



Volunteers from Chennai District Election Office assist a person with disability at Urdu Girls Primary School on Arathoon Salai in Royapuram.

A physically challenged woman crawls to her booth in Shenoy Nagar.



On a modified tricycle with a roof, this woman drew eyeballs for her commitment, at St. George's School in Kilpauk.



A green polling booth at Sri Lakshmi Higher Secondary School in Tiruvallur.



An elongated cloth roof at Chennai Corporation School in Thiruvannamiyur served as a shield from the sun, for voters.

PHOTOS : B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM , RAGHUNATHAN SR, PRABHU M, JOHAN SATHYADAS J, SRINATH M

Big questions for young minds

Philosophising is usually, and often erroneously, associated with hoary hair, even lack of hair. Alwarpet resident Rhea Kuthoore seeks to break that stereotype by introducing children to philosophical inquiry through a systematic programme



LIFY THOMAS

“Philosophising with children”: that is how Rhea Kuthoore headlines her LinkedIn page. That is a rare value proposition to come across in most places, not just on a LinkedIn profile.

Rhea considers getting children to grapple with philosophical questions a natural thing to do, as she herself had been through that routine at home while growing up.

“My dad in particular would want us to put on our thinking caps. For instance, he would ask: “Do you know when your desire becomes greed?”,” she recalls.

The idea that children should be served a regular diet of tough questions got reinforced at school, thanks to Rhea’s teachers at Abacus Montessori School. A kindergarten teacher even maintained a diary of what her students would share.

Recently, when Rhea met this teacher, the latter recalled a conversation between Rhea and her classmate. Rhea had discussed with her peer that her mother was “going to office”. Surprised to

learn that it was her mom going to office, the friend corrected Rhea that it should be “dad going to office.”

“So I used to think my mom is my dad. These anecdotes are interesting because as children we may not know how to make inferences, we start observing the norms of society and imagine it differently,” says Rhea, an Alwarpet resident.

Rhea pursued an undergraduate programme in Liberal Arts from Ashoka University and a masters in Childhood Studies from Rutgers University in the United States. This was followed by a two-year stint at Sholai School in

Kodaikanal where she started exploring children’s literature.

“A lot of my learning also came from organisations outside the country including PLATO (Philosophy Learning and Teaching Organisation),” says Rhea, who is in her late 20s.

Rhea currently works with educators and teachers, offering classes online. For in-person knowledge sharing, Rhea has opened a dedicated space in Chennai for children and adults to explore.

More than 100 of her favourite philosophical picture books from around the world have been



▼ Rhea Kuthoore during a workshop; and the space in Royapettah called “Room of Children’s Philosophises” that she operates from. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Summer camp in May

- Room of Children’s Philosophises is conducting a summer philosophy camp in May for children, ideally suited for those between 11 and 14 years of age.
- Rhea Kuthoore and Jigar Bhalani would be the resourcepersons helping children discover their philosophical voice and self through the workshop.
- Participants will get to ask big questions, ethical and existential, that perplex them. They will have a chance to understand themselves and the world around them, all through stories and dialogue.
- The camp is happening at D3, Third floor, Ashok Swetha Apartments, Royapettah. For details, call 8816933078.



showcased at Room of Children’s Philosophises. The space at an apartment complex in Royapettah functions as a reading room. Workshops are also conducted in this space. She believes that philosophising begins with asking questions and our understanding of an issue deepens as the questions around it are refined. And she is hugely familiar with the J. Krishnamurthi style of inquiry, having been associated with a school in-

spired by his philosophy, for two years.

“This is a small space to listen to voices of children and their many questions that often goes unheard. You might love the stories in the books displayed, but I want them to understand the story as a philosophical puzzle and get them to think together about the question,” she says.

Know more about Rhea’s mission at childrendoingphilosophy.org

Summer Quiz Camp 2026 coming up in May

Open to students from Grades 5 to 11, the five-day camp focusses on building skills that go beyond textbooks

With the long summer break often leading to increased screen time, Chennai-based leading quizzing firm X Quiz It is offering students a productive alternative through its Summer Quiz Camp 2026, a five-day programme designed to keep young minds engaged and curious.

A press release notes that open to students from Grades 5 to 11, the camp focusses on building skills that go beyond textbooks. Participants will learn techniques in smart deduction, develop lateral thinking abilities, and stay updated with current affairs through interactive and high-energy sessions.

A highlight of the programme is a series of 'Ask Me Anything' (AMA) sessions with experienced quizmasters, giving students direct ac-

cess to insights, strategies and real-world quizzing experience.

The camp is designed for both beginners and seasoned quizzers, making it accessible to any student with curiosity and enthusiasm for learning, the release adds.

All participants will receive certificates, while top performers will be offered opportunities for one-on-one mentoring and internships.

Programme details

Dates: May 18-22 (5 days; 60-75 minutes per day)

Eligibility: Grades 5-7 and 8-11

Fee: ₹2,500

Registration:

rzp.io/rzp/xqicamp2026

For details, call 9841270711 / 9962744699 / 6362209664



From the event

High-octane cultural performances at school in Perungudi

Bharath Dass Matriculation Higher Secondary School in Perungudi celebrated its 29th Annual Day with immense enthusiasm, transforming the auditorium into a vibrant hub of talent and creativity.

According to a press release, themed "Waves of Joy", the celebration clearly reflected the hard

work put in by the teachers and students. A galaxy of dignitaries graced the occasion.

The correspondent K. Sathya Balan welcomed the gathering. The principal Bhanumathy Manoharan presented the annual report.

The cultural programme featured a mesmerising array of per-

formances.

Awards were presented to meritorious students for excellence in academics and sports.

The chief guest Ranjini Christopher, vice president, executive committee, Alliance Francaise, Chennai, was all praise for holistic education provided by the school.

Parkinson's Awareness Month: initiatives to empower individuals and caregivers

Parivarthan for Parkinson's Foundation organised its 'In Gratitude' event on April 18, bringing together donors, people living with Parkinson's, healthcare professionals, and members of the public. The event showcased the foundation's range of services in Arumbakkam and Besant Nagar, while featuring heartfelt performances by its members, highlighting both resilience and community spirit.

Held as part of World Parkinson's Awareness Month, the event aimed to increase understanding of Parkinson's, the second most common neurological disorder, and emphasise the importance of timely support and intervention, said a release.

Earlier this month, Parivarthan also conducted a Deep Brain Stimulation (DBS) screening in collaboration with Kauvery Hospital, Vadapalani, to assess the eligibility of individuals with Parkinson's for this advanced treatment option.

The foundation is hosting multiple awareness initiatives and support group meetings throughout April to empower individuals and caregivers with the right knowledge and resources.

If you or someone you know with Parkinson's is looking for support and access to the right resources, call +91 96000 52531.

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The college won the 'Academic Excellence' award from International Rotary and Lions on April 17, 2026.

Plans etched for Vivekananda College's anniversary fete

RKMVC Alumni Association is organising a celebration on May 2; two of the alumni will be honoured on the occasion

RKMVC Alumni Association invites alumni, their spouses and family members to celebrate the 80th anniversary of RKM Vivekananda College on May 2 (between 4.30 p.m. and 6.45 p.m.).

Two of their 1957 alumni T. S. Vijayaraghavan IAS (retd) and P. V. Ramana (founder and chairman of ITM

Institutions, Mumbai) will be honoured on the occasion. This will be followed by karaoke musical evening by Team Paadarivom Padipparivom, an international music group led by Nageswar, an old student from the B Com 2004 batch.

Entry fee is ₹100 per person.

Light refreshment will be served

during the social hour (4.30 p.m. to 5 p.m.).

Register at <https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLScWphmOmL8wcwnTs2ejZotn46LZhgnhlhS5kCeBna3snVtdvQ/viewform>

Scholarships for deserving students

Dream India E&C Trust is inviting applications from students across Tamil Nadu who have completed Class 10 and Class XII for educational scholarships under the project "Education for All".

Students from government or rural government schools who have completed 10th or 12th in the year 2026 and planning for higher studies will be given priority.

Students from private schools coming from single parent households or with guardians can also apply. Scholarship for higher studies would be in the range of ₹15,000 to ₹25,000. Those selected for scholarship would be guided by a mentor. Last year, the Dream India team processed scholarship for over 200 students across various locations in Tamil Nadu, Bangalore and Mumbai, said a press release.

The applications would be analysed by the trustees of Dream India and processed within a time frame of three to four weeks. For details, WhatsApp 99406 75570.

The link to apply is <https://www.dreamindia.org/scholarship/>

Online writing workshop

Learner Circle is conducting a workshop for children aged eight to eighteen who enjoy writing and creativity. Whether a child is starting from scratch or already has a story, the programme guide them step by step, says a release.

The story-writing workshop helps beginners write their first story, and the author accelerator supports children in completing their writing.

The comics workshop introduces children to turning ideas into visual stories and comic panels. The children will learn to express their ideas clearly and confidently, the release adds.

For details, visit: learnercircle.in/workshop

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Songs from the 'First Superstar'

Satrangi's next presentation 'The First Superstar' will be held on April 26 from 5:45 p.m. at Teach Auditorium, Taramani.

This programme will feature memorable songs picturised on the legendary actor Rajesh Khanna from movies such as Anand, Mere Jeevan Saathi, Aradhana, Aap Ki Kasam, , An-daz, Daag, Mehbooba, Namak Haram and Kati Patang.

Tickets for this event are priced at ₹500 and ₹300 and will be home-delivered on calling 9884778073.

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